

Teaching Statement

Haiming (Richard) Li · Lehigh University · haimingli.com

Intermediate microeconomics starts with scarcity, and so does my research. My papers study how people respond when a policy changes their access to something, such as a cannabis market in the next state or a bed in a psychiatric hospital. I think about my students in a similar way. They have other courses, jobs, and deadlines, and I usually cannot tell what is not working until they show me. I try to design courses that use their time well and that tell me early when something is going wrong.

I taught Intermediate Microeconomic Analysis (ECO 146) online as an Adjunct Professor at Lehigh in Summer 2026, and I will teach Econometric Software (ECO 301/403) in Spring 2027. Before that I led recitations as a teaching assistant for Principles of Economics, Statistical Methods, and Introduction to Finance. I also gave a guest lecture in Introduction to Health Humanities at Moravian University.

Students try first. In ECO 146, every class ended with a short exercise that students answered before I showed a solution. The same skill came back on a graded problem set later that week with new numbers. In the second class, for example, students turned the nominal price of a \$12 sandwich into a real price. On Problem Set 1 they did the same calculation for a \$90 textbook rental and decided whether it had become more expensive. Trying first shows students what they do not yet know, and it shows me too.

From worked examples to independent work. When a topic is new, I solve a complete example and show every step. Then I hand more of the steps to the students. Problem Set 2 walked through a market demand problem in six numbered steps. On the midterm, students reached the same answer in four. I also bring each core skill back in a new setting. Horizontal summation appeared five times in five weeks, starting with a wheat market in class and ending with the price a price-discriminating monopolist would set.

Different courses, different sticking points. As a recitation leader I learned that students get stuck in different places in different courses. First-year students in Principles of Economics mostly struggled to understand a concept and to see when it applies. Students in Introduction to Finance usually understood the idea but lost track in the calculation, and in my first semester with that course I did not give them enough help with it. The next year I rewrote my recitation slides with fully worked solutions that explain the reasoning behind each step, and I added a short calculation exercise for every major concept. My evaluations in the course improved clearly the following spring and ended above the university average.

Individual attention matters as much as course design. I use name cards until I know every student, because in a weekly recitation it is easy to learn only the names of students who speak up. After a hard topic, my follow-up message tells students exactly what to review, for example the meaning of elasticity and the midpoint formula, and asks them to bring their attempts to office hours. One student wrote that “he even knows all of our names which a lot of TAs don’t know.” Another wrote that when they wanted to go over an exam, I “made time that exact day.”

Adjusting from evidence. Most ECO 146 assignments were graded automatically, so I could see within a day how the class had done. The midterm and the problem sets showed two weak spots: drawing graphs and the calculus behind optimization. I gave both more time in the remaining classes and pointed students to a four-page math toolkit I had written for the course. My recitation evaluations in Principles of Economics were 4.61 in Spring 2024 and 4.54 in Fall 2022, compared with university averages of 4.31 and 4.39.

I also work on teaching as a skill. I have completed the first four modules of the Effective Teaching Practices course from the Association of College and University Educators (ACUE). This fall I am in the AI Innovator Track of Lehigh’s Strategic Methods for AI-Responsive Teaching program, where I am designing an AI-related resource for an economics course. I will use it in Econometric Software, which builds on the statistics students already know and moves from describing data to regression, hypothesis testing, and simple prediction methods. I am teaching it in Python because Python handles the prediction material well and

because one language per course lets students go further with it. I can teach the same material in R or Stata.

Mentoring. I came to economics through an undergraduate degree in business administration and a master's degree in applied economics, so I enjoy talking with students who are still working out where economics fits in their plans. I have advised master's students on using Stata and ArcGIS in their projects, written a recommendation letter for an undergraduate from my recitation, and talked with many students about what economists do. Several are now thinking about a master's degree or a Ph.D. in economics, and some plan to take my course in the spring. In a department, I would like to supervise undergraduate research with public health and policy data and help advise students on courses and careers.

Courses I can teach. Principles of Microeconomics and Macroeconomics; Intermediate Microeconomics; Statistics, Econometrics, and Econometric Software in Stata, R, or Python; Health Economics and the Economics of Health Policy; Introduction to Finance. I would also like to develop a course on evaluating health and substance use policy with public data.